

European Research Council (ERC) Grant Agreement

Project Multi-Agent Ref: ERC-2026-STG-SOLARML
Core Terms, Conditions, and Financial Eligibility Rules

1. Eligible and Ineligible Costs (Article 6)

1.1 General Eligibility Criteria

To be deemed eligible for funding under the ERC framework, direct costs must meet the following cumulative conditions: * They must be actually incurred by the beneficiary during the project duration. * They must be indicated in the estimated overall budget set out in Annex 2. * They must be incurred in connection with the action as described in Annex 1 and necessary for its implementation. * They must be identifiable and verifiable, recorded in the beneficiary's accounting records in accordance with the accounting standards of the host institution.

1.2 Direct Personnel Costs (Budget Line A.1)

- Costs for specific researchers, postdocs, PhD students, and technical staff are eligible provided they are directly assigned to the implementation of the action.
- **Timesheets & Effort Reporting:** All personnel charging partial or full monthly effort to the grant must maintain signed timesheets certifying the exact percentage of monthly working hours dedicated exclusively to the ERC project.

1.3 Operational and Consumable Costs (Budget Line B.2)

- **Cloud & High-Performance Computing (HPC):** Expenses incurred for cloud compute credits (e.g., AWS, Google Cloud) or localized HPC cluster allocations are fully eligible *only if* they are dedicated exclusively to the computational models (e.g., neural networks, simulations) outlined in the scientific proposal.
- General-purpose office software or non-scientific cloud storage allocations are explicitly **ineligible** under direct costs and must be covered via indirect institutional overheads.

1.4 Equipment and Infrastructure (Budget Line B.3)

- Only the **depreciation costs** of equipment, infrastructure, or other assets directly used for the action are eligible. Capital cost spending for hardware (e.g., specialized server racks, GPU workstations) must be amortized over the asset's expected lifespan according to the host institution's standard practice.
- Only the portion of equipment usage dedicated strictly to the ERC project during its runtime is chargeable.

2. Travel and Subsistence Allowances (Article 6.2.B.1)

- Travel costs and related subsistence allowances are eligible if they are directly linked to the dissemination of project results or critical field campaigns (e.g., observatory visits, collaborative workshops).
- **The Fly America / Fly European Equivalence:** Travel must be economy class using the most economical direct routing.
- **Geographical Restrictions:** Travel outside the European Union or Associated Countries requires explicit scientific justification in the periodic technical report proving its direct impact on the project's milestones.

3. Budget Flexibility and Reallocations (Article 5.3)

- **The 20% Amendment Rule:** Beneficiaries are permitted to transfer budget allocations between direct cost categories (e.g., moving funds from *Travel* to *Consumables*) without a formal grant amendment, provided that the transfer does not imply a substantial change to the core scientific work program (Annex 1).
- **Personnel Transfers:** Transferring funds out of *Budget Line A.1 (Personnel)* to cover equipment or operational shortfalls is highly restricted and requires written prior approval from the ERC Project Officer if the cumulative transfer exceeds 10% of the total allocated staff budget.

4. Open Science and Publications (Article 29)

- **Mandatory Open Access:** The beneficiary must ensure open access (free of charge online access for any user) to all peer-reviewed scientific publications relating to its results.
- **Eligible Fees:** Article Processing Charges (APCs) are eligible for funding during the lifetime of the action *only if* the venue is a fully open-access journal (hybrid journal fees are ineligible unless explicitly authorized under specific transitional agreements).